



Elena Andreeva and Kevin McNeer (eds). *Slavery in the Modern Middle East and North Africa. Exploitation and Resistance from the 19th Century – Present Day*. London: I.B. Tauris. 2024. 254 pp. ISBN 978-0-7556-4793-4. \$84.00.

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The institution of slavery beyond the Atlantic world started receiving academic attention only in the 1980s, but scholars have enthusiastically expanded the research on the topic with a variety of contributions covering a wide range of areas and epochs. Collective volumes are especially interesting, as they allow readers to grasp the differences and commonalities of the various forms of bondage through time and space. These works are usually centered around a specific area, civilization, or period of time, with each author analyzing one aspect of this multifaceted phenomenon. Some instances of this type of volumes are *The Economics of the Indian Ocean Slave Trade in the Nineteenth Century* (Clarence-Smith, 1989), *Abolition and its aftermath in Indian Ocean Africa and Asia* (Campbell, 2005), and *Traites et esclavages en Afrique orientale et dans l’Océan Indien* (Medard *et al.*, 2013). Alternatively, collections are given a global range, presenting the variety of slavery in different societies throughout history in a comparative perspective, such as *Critical Readings on Global Slavery* (Pargas & Roşu, 2018), *Slaving Zones* (Fynn-Paul & Pargas, 2018), and *The Palgrave Handbook of Global Slavery throughout History* (Pargas & Schiel, 2023).

The volume *Slavery in the Modern Middle East and North Africa*, edited by Elena Andreeva and Kevin McNeer, is not an actual follow-up of these previous collective works. Rather, it is part of a series aiming at exploring the titular region with a particular attention on the cultural practices influencing sexuality and family life. The title of the collection aims to explore slavery in relation to «gender and racial relations, social and economic networks, cultural production [...], formal and informal institutions [...] and cultural heritage» (p. 1), while searching for commonalities connecting different geographical areas. The book, resulting from a (not specified) conference (p. 1), is centered on the last two centuries and covers several issues from individual biographies to the process of emancipation, passing through the narratives surrounding the institution. After an introduction from the editors, the volume is divided into four parts, dedicated to enslaved women, resistance and abolition, identity preservation, and contemporary forms of slavery, respectively.

The first part, *Gender and Sexuality: Female Slaves*, is divided into two chapters. The former, “Ziba Khanum of Yazd: an enslaved African woman in nineteenth-century Iran”, has been written by Anthony A. Lee, a retired lecturer and now independent scholar who is currently studying African slavery in Iran. The chapter focuses on the lives of the titular person and her son, connecting their biographies with «race, gender, religion, elite social and economic networks, the nature of slavery and the value of subaltern history» (p. 10) in Iranian history. Recovering the voices of the subalterns is a

challenging mission as the related sources are scarce and scattered. However, as proved by Claire Anderson (2012), this is not an impossible task for a skilled historian. Lee did an excellent job in bringing Ziba Khanun and her son back to the collective memory. The rediscovery of subordinates' lives is fundamental for expanding the comprehension of a given epoch, as it allows us to overcome the dominant narrative by presenting new perspectives.

The latter chapter of this section is "On the multivalence of women's captivity narratives: seventeenth to nineteenth centuries", by Irvin Cemil Schick, an expert in Islamic art, gender, and sexuality. It analyzes a corpus of stories circulating in Europe and North America between the 17th and 19th centuries about white Christian women captured in the Mediterranean by Muslim "pirates". Questioning their veracity, Schick highlights the propagandistic implications of these publications, which justified imperialism by reinforcing racist perspectives and traditional gender roles. The Christian white woman was a victim of the cruel and lustful brown Muslims and the European civilized men had to halt such barbarity by force. This is a powerful reminder that sources, including personal memoirs and fictional works, are never completely neutral.

The second part of the book, *Resistance and Abolition*, is composed of four chapters covering the Ottoman Empire, the Arabian Peninsula, Central Asia, and Morocco, respectively. Chapter 3, "The gradual elimination of female slavery in the late Ottoman Empire: institutional change", from Kadir Yildirim, an expert in labor and class history in the Ottoman Empire, analyzes the paths to emancipation. The author explains how different groups of enslaved people required different approaches and strategies in order to achieve freedom. While the liberation of slaves employed for labor and domestic service mostly relied on legal abolition (influenced by foreign pressure), the emancipation of concubines needed a reform of what Yildirim calls "informal institutions", meaning the ensemble of moral values, customs, and social conventions. Furthermore, economic and political changes were required in the areas which supplied these women, in order to prevent their enslavement.

Chapter 4, "The social construction of slavery, injustice and manumission on the Gulf Coast of Arabia and Oman in the 1920s and 1930s", was written by Jerzy Zdanowski, a historian whose research focuses on slavery in the Gulf area during the late 19th and early 20th centuries. The author aims to explore the relationship between slave and master, which was more than a simple owner-slave bond. Instead, it was a multilayered social construction with its own norms, customs, and mutual duties and rights for both slaves and masters.

Both Yildirim and Zdanowski deal with the complications related to a full-fledged emancipation, proving that slavery had social and political, besides economic, values. Therefore, legal abolition was not sufficient to grant manumitted people freedom and equality. Total emancipation required two main developments: a radical mutation of the

norms and customs surrounding slavery and the removal of all the factors that made the slave trade a remunerative business. As Yildirim (p. 63) points out, no matter how many bans a given state imposed, as long as the demand persisted, slave traders would continue trafficking human beings anyway.

Chapter 5, by Elena Andreeva, a historian focused on East and West relations, is titled “Slavery on the Central Asian Steppe in the works of Nikolai Karazin (1842-1908)”. The titular Russian artist and writer provided a detailed representation of slavery in Turkestan at the time of the tsarist empire’s conquest. Karazin viewed Central Asia as a dangerous and backwards region, and he was highly sympathetic towards enslaved Iranians. Andreeva argues that the artists’ representation is ambivalent: although critical of the most brutal aspects of the Russian conquests, it reinforced the civilizing mission trope. Indeed, similarly to Europeans, the Russians used the abolitionist mission as a justification for conquests. Like Schick’s chapter in the first part of the volume, Andreeva’s work is stimulating a reflection on the representations of the “Orient” and the implications of such depictions. It underlines how each source is the product of a particular cultural *milieu* rather than an objective observation.

Chapter 6, titled “Mercy releases: manumission practices in Tetouan, Morocco (1860-1960)”, is provided by the historical anthropologist Josep Lluís Mateo Dieste. The paper deals with the last phase of emancipation in the North African city, with a particular attention to the legal formulas provided by the Maliki madhhab (“school of religious jurisprudence”) for freeing enslaved persons. Apart from a nod at the European colonial presence, the chapter does not analyze any other development connected to the emancipation. As a result, the inhabitants of Tetouan do not appear like actual individuals, but emerge as a mass of bigots deprived of any personality who only emancipated slaves to gain bonuses for the afterlife. The “Islamic slavery” trope, or idea that religious principles can explain an institution as multifaceted as slavery has been rejected by several scholars, including Behnaz Mirzai (2017: 20-21), Abdul Sherif (in Campbell 2005: 103; 2010: 218), Henry Medard (in Medard et al. 2013: 49), and M’hamed Oualdi (2024: 35-36), who proved how simplistic and overgeneralizing it is. A few Qurānic lines and a handful of aḥādīth (“sayings of the Prophet Muhammad [Muḥammad]”) are not sufficient to explain the complexity of such an institution: the social, cultural, economic, and political specificities of the society under analysis must also be considered.

The third part, *Preserving Identity and Tradition*, has two very similar chapters, both dealing with the cultures of the descendants of enslaved Africans, their identity, peculiar traditions, and the way they perceive themselves within the framework of the society they live in. The former chapter, “Afro-Baloch communities in modern Iran and their healing traditions”, has been written by Maryam Nourzaei, who is a linguist. It focuses on the Afro-descendants in Iranian Baluchistan, with a particular attention on the traditional healing practices through music and chanting. The latter chapter,

“Transmuted memories: slavery and its shadow on the island of Soqotra” by the writer, filmmaker, and translator Kevin McNeer and the area expert Sarali Gintsburg, is very similar to Nourzaei’s work, but it focuses on the Yemeni island of Soqotra and the music and dances performed by people of African origins.

While the general topic is fascinating, this whole section is particularly problematic due to its patronizing and almost insulting approach. For some reason, Nourzaei, McNeer, and Gintsburg want slave descendants in Iran and Soqotra to admit their Africanness. If they had deemed a specific performance, word, or piece of clothing to be African, it must be African, and the individuals involved had to perceive themselves accordingly. This imposition is clear in McNeer’s and Gintsburg’s statement that the people they interviewed «showcase this Africanness [but] de-emphasize, mask or even decline to recognize African roots in conversation with the authors» (p. 161). As a result, Afro-Baluchis and Afro-Soqotris are made the objects, rather than the subjects, of the research: their self-representation and self-classification are subordinated to the argument pursued by the three scholars.

The fourth and final part, *Slavery in a Post-Slavery World*, is centered around the present-day world. Chapter 9 by Dina Al Raffie, a political scientist specialized in terrorism and counter-terrorism, is titled “Enslaved by the street: contemporary forms of slavery among the street children of Cairo”. It analyzes the vicious circle of abuse and dependence that street urchins of the Egyptian capital are forced into, showing how their conditions resemble slavery. Furthermore, the author employs the various appearances of these youth in the rich Egyptian cinematographic industry to analyze how society perceives and represents them. Al Raffie’s contribution presents in a couple of occasions some slightly naïve comments, which are the definition of enslavement as «racialised» (p. 188) and the statement that for «the conventional forms of organized slavery [...] the solution [...] was abolition [while] many factors enabling slavery today are socioeconomic, cultural and psychological» (p. 189). The former statement ignores the fact that, in opposition to the Atlantic trade, enslavability in the Middle East was not primarily driven by racial considerations. The latter sentence does not take into account that any form of slavery was rooted in social, economic, and cultural issues, as previously clarified by Yilidirim and Zdanowski. Nevertheless, these are minor inaccuracies that do not spoil the excellent contribution provided by this chapter to the academic debate over slavery. Al Raffie deals with a very sensitive topic in a detailed yet respectful way, while avoiding pity-baiting. Her work is really impressive in showing the multifaceted nature of enslavement and other bonded relations based on extreme dependency on a person or environment.

The last chapter, “Yazidi women and girls held as slaves under the Islamic State: healing wounds and reassessing doctrines”, by area expert Lana Ravandi-Fadai, recounts the recovery of the victims of enslavement by the hands of Daesh’s men for sexual

purposes between 2014 and 2017 and their return to their communities. The “Islamic slavery” perspective already detected in Dieste’s work is even worse in this chapter. The author explains the tragedy of the Yazidi people as the forced interpretation of «old justifications for enslavement and slave-trading» (p. 212) by the extremists of the Islamic State. No insight into sexual slavery is actually given: the chapter only reproduces a pamphlet explaining the righteousness of sexually exploiting prisoners and reports the reactions of some Islamic scholars. There is no consistent analysis, and the work mainly relies on shock value. The capture and rape of Yazidi women is merely explained as something embedded in the terrorists’ nature: they were Islamic extremists on the loose and therefore acted as such. Overall, the chapter gives the impression that the author wanted to speak about Daesh’s atrocities (a well-known topic), the consequential reactions of the Muslim community worldwide, and her personal experience in Iraq. The reader is left with the idea that the issue of slavery has been shoehorned within it.

In conclusion, the book is a mixed bag. It explores a wide range of areas and epochs, but the results are either very satisfying or really disappointing. It is recommended for scholars who are already familiar with slavery in the Muslim world, as they would find valuable insights and stimuli for reflections and further research. Conversely, neophytes might find some parts confusing, even misleading.

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